

☑ For the items that do need action, have a consistent plan; those that don't, put them where they should be.

Perhaps we should add a fourth concise line:

☑ Back up often.

You should formulate a policy for yourself to keep things in order, but we'll tell you a couple of things just so you're aware that you don't have a proper policy in place!

First off, constantly being alerted of new mail is a distraction. We've gotten used to it, but ask yourself if you really need Outlook to check for mail every five minutes – and whether you need to be notified each and every time. Chances are you don't. You'll deal better with e-mail if you give it a time and a time-slot. (Only you can decide whether you need that to be twice a day or six times.) It's a generalised suggestion, but how about choosing to only be alerted to important mail – that is, mails from a certain sender, or those with a certain subject line?

Now, for when you do sit down to “deal” with your mail, you can reduce some of the clutter immediately: look at the list of unread e-mails and quickly respond to those that demand just a couple of lines. Let those not remain on the list – and in your head. To reduce the clutter a little more, delete what you're not never going to deal with. Accept it: you've got a hoard of e-mails that you're never, ever going to respond to or take some action upon, but they're there. Learn to decide what items belong in this category, and delete them when they arrive.

Well, here's a gentle way out (because we know it hurts): spend some time right now and move all such items to a newly-created folder (more on this later), take a backup (more on this later), then delete them forever. Three months down the line, look back on whether you needed them! Cases in point: forwards you're not going to read. Newsletters you're not going to read. Social networking requests you're not going to respond to...

Of course, keeping spam out is rather more than half the story. We'll come to that in a while.

Folders And Files

If you've never bothered to organise your Outlook folders and have left them at the default, you probably have one very large file that contains all your mails. This .PST file (like we said) could get corrupted, and Outlook could take longer to open. Then there's the matter of good organisation: if you split your mail into multiple .PST files, you can choose to open only the one(s) you want – and you'll see them listed separately in the folder list on the left. If you have sub-folders, you'll get smaller lists when you expand a particular folder than if you had one, large folder.

Let's take a typical scenario and say you have three kinds of mails – Work, Personal, and Newsletters. Right now, they're all in one .PST file (unless you've archived some of them). What you need to do is create two more. Go to File > New > Outlook Data File. Supply a filename, and you'll get the options to set a password for it, and to name it. This name – say “Personal” – is

what will show up in Outlook. To avoid confusion, you might want to keep the filename and this name the same.

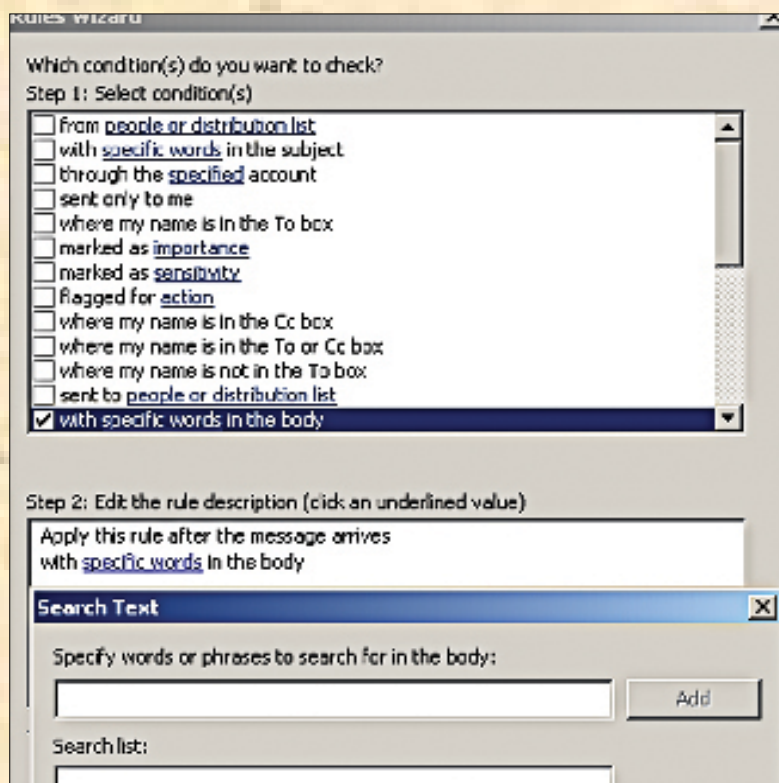
The newly-created file will open up immediately in Outlook, unpopulated, of course. Move your “personal” messages into this one by dragging and dropping. (Before that, if you'd like, you can create sub-folders by right-clicking on the name and choosing the appropriate option.) Then, you can choose to close it (again, by right-clicking on the name). Whenever you need to open it, you just do File > Open > Outlook Data File.

When you try to open an Outlook Data File as above, Outlook will look for files in the default location – note that path. Later, in Explorer, look under that folder, and you'll see all your .PST files. Back these up on a regular basis, very preferably to a different hard disk or to DVD. You'll be able to use them after you re-install Windows or Office – or on a different computer. Restoring the files to a new installation of Outlook is as simple as it gets: choose File > Import and Export..., then select Import from another program or file. Click Next. Highlight Personal Folder File (PST) and click Next again. Say Browse, and select the .PST files you want to recover. (Make sure you've selected Replace duplicates with items imported.) Then click Next and Finish.

The Clean Inbox, #1

The straightforward way to make every incoming message go where it should – the appropriate folder, that is – is to use Rules in Outlook. Thankfully, there's a Rules Wizard.

If you're hearing the term “Mail Rules” for



Caption